Lesson 3

Adolescent Rebellion

"Listen, my son, to your father's instruction and do not forsake your mother's teaching."
(Proverbs 1:8)

Rebellion: an act of defiance toward those who are in authority or in control

Adolescents are under tremendous pressure in today's society. Premarital sex, drugs, gangs, pornography, and a host of other societal ills threaten to win them over into sinful lives and destruction. As parents, we sometimes feel helpless and overwhelmed and don't know where to turn. Fortunately, the Bible is a great source of wisdom and guidance for raising adolescents. Bottom line, the best thing you can do to raise healthy and God-fearing children is to train them in God's word, keep them away from bad influences, and teach them to obey and respect your authority through love and discipline.

Synopsis

Parents are commanded to take an active role in training their children.[1] They need to teach their adolescents God's word and introduce them to the powerful advice and counsel that God provides for young people. The Bible is not just for adults. God speaks directly to young people on numerous occasions.

So listen closely adolescents! Here is some sound advice you would be wise to follow…

Train a child in the way he should go and when he is old he will not turn from it.
(Proverbs 22:6)[1]

Even a child is known by his actions, by whether his conduct is pure and right.
(Proverbs 20:11)[2]

Set An Example for Others: Just because you are a young person doesn't mean that you can "get away" with bad behavior and not be accountable. Even the actions of children are judged according to whether they are pure and right.[2] Young people are instructed to set a good example for other believers.[3] How you live your lives is extremely important!

Parents and adults are told not to look down on you just because you are young.[3] In fact, God wants to use you to set an example for adults and other Christians in terms of how you live your life, how you talk to other people, how you love others, your faith, and your purity.[3]

So, never think that what you do as a young person doesn't matter or will be excused by God because you are young. God wants you to be happy and follow your heart,[4] but remember that everything you do—even the things you do as a young person—will ultimately be brought into judgment by the Lord.[4]

Listen to Instruction: If your parents are "God-fearing" Christians who teach you the Bible, you should listen to their advice and accept their instruction.[5] You will be wise if you do,[6,7] and

Don't let anyone look down on you because you are young,
but set an example for the believers in speech, in life,
in love, in faith, and in purity.
(1 Timothy 4:12)[3]

Be happy, young man, while you are young, and let your heart give you joy in the days of your youth. Follow the ways of your heart and whatever your eyes see, but know that for all these things God will bring you to judgment.
(Ecclesiastes 11:9)[4]

Listen, my son, to your father's instruction and do
not forsake your mother's teaching.
(Proverbs 1:8)[5]

Listen to advice and accept instruction, and in the
end you will be wise.
(Proverbs 19:20)[6]

A wise son heeds his father's instruction, but a
mocker does not listen to rebuke.
(Proverbs 13:1)[7]

the knowledge you gain will be important to you throughout your lifetime.[8] If you don't follow your parents' instructions, bad things often happen[9] and at the end of your life, you may look back and wish that you had listened to what they told you.[10]

Obey Your Parents: Once again, if your parents are Christians and being Christ-like in their actions, you should try to obey everything they tell you to do.[11,12] The Lord says He is pleased when you do this.[11] Stop rebelling and arguing over every little thing; submit your will to your parents' will and try to live the kind of life they are training you to live.[13]

Keep Good Company: No matter how well your parents have trained you in the truth, and no matter how often you have been to church or Sunday school, be careful with whom you associate. If you allow yourself to associate with "bad company,"[14,15] or young people who are rebelling against authority and against society,[16] you are putting yourself at risk.

Hold on to instruction, do not let it go;
guard it well, for it is your life.
(Proverbs 4:13)[8]

He who scorns instruction will pay for it, but he
who respects a command is rewarded.
(Proverbs 13:13)[9]

At the end of your life you will groan, when your flesh and body are spent. You will say, "How I hated discipline! How my heart spurned correction! I would not obey my teachers or listen to my instructors. I have come to the brink of utter ruin in the midst of the whole assembly."
(Proverbs 5:11-14)[10]

Children, obey your parents in everything,
for this pleases the Lord.
(Colossians 3:20)[11]

Children, obey your parents in the Lord, for this is right.
(Ephesians 6:1)[12]

My son, give me your heart
and let your eyes keep to my ways.
(Proverbs 23:26)[13]

Do not be misled: "Bad company corrupts good character."
(1 Corinthians 15:33)[14]

Just because you think you have good morals and couldn't possibly be led astray, don't fool yourself! King Solomon, one of the wisest men who ever lived, said that "He who walks with the wise grows wise, but a companion of fools suffers harm."[17] If King Solomon met your friends, would he think they were foolish or wise? If your so-called "friends" try to coax you into sin, don't give in to them.[18] Better yet, find some different friends!

Accept Discipline: Most young people hate discipline. It's hard for them to understand that discipline is actually a sign of love. The Bible clearly states that God Himself disciplines those He loves, just as a father disciplines the son he loves.[19] If you ignore the discipline that your parents give you, and don't learn from it, you are really only hurting yourself,[20] and being foolish.[21]

A Final Note: Sometimes it doesn't seem possible to live like a Christian in today's society. There are so many pressures and so

Do not set foot on the path of the wicked or
walk in the way of evil men.
(Proverbs 4:14)[15]

Fear the LORD and the king, my son,
and do not join with the rebellious.
(Proverbs 24:21)[16]

He who walks with the wise grows wise,
but a companion of fools suffers harm.
(Proverbs 13:20)[17]

My son, if sinners entice you,
do not give in to them.
(Proverbs 1:10)[18]

My son, do not despise the LORD'S discipline and do not
resent his rebuke, because the LORD disciplines those
he loves, as a father the son he delights in.
(Proverbs 3:11-12)[19]

He who ignores discipline despises himself, but whoever
heeds correction gains understanding.
(Proverbs 15:32)[20]

A fool spurns his father's discipline, but whoever
heeds correction shows prudence.
(Proverbs 15:5)[21]

many temptations. However, God promises that there is a way to make it through—by living according to His word,[22] and by honoring your father and mother.[23]

God's Guidance

God wants us to be obedient to our parents, but He also wants us to be obedient to Him.[24-26] We show our love for God when we obey His commands (as found in the holy scriptures) and follow the instructions He gives for us in the Bible.[27,28]

How can a young man keep his way pure? By living according to your word.
(Psalm 119:9)[22]

Honor your father and mother…that it may go well with you and that you may enjoy long life on the earth.
(Ephesians 6:2)[23]

Walk in the ways I command you, that it may go well with you.
(Jeremiah 7:23)[24]

Obey me and do everything I command you, and you will be my people, and I will be your God.
(Jeremiah 11:4)[25]

Why do you call me, 'Lord, Lord,' and do not do what I say?
(Luke 6:46)[26]

This is love for God: to obey his commands.
(1 John 5:3)[26]

If you love me, you will obey what I command.
(John 14:15)[27]

If you obey my commands, you will remain in my love, just as I have obeyed my Father's commands and remain in his love.
(John 15:10)[28]

I have hidden your word in my heart that I might not sin against you.
(Psalm 119:11)[29]

Unfortunately, many adolescents are stubborn and resist reading God's word. They can't obey God because they have never taken the time to study the Bible and see how God instructs them to live their lives.

One of the best things you can do to stay out of trouble and live a holy life is to hide God's word in your heart.[29-31] God's advice is always perfect,[32] flawless,[33] trustworthy,[34] and eternal[35- 37]— and He loves it when we follow his commandments.

Reading and memorizing scriptures will help you resist evil and do what is right. God Himself promises that if we obey His commandments things will always turn out better for us.[38]

When your words came, I ate them; they were my joy and my heart's delight, for I bear your name, O LORD God Almighty.
(Jeremiah 15:16)[30]

I will not neglect your word.
(Psalm 119:16)[31]

The law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul.
(Psalm 19:7)[32]

Every word of God is flawless.
(Proverbs 30:5)[33]

The statutes you have laid down are righteous;
they are fully trustworthy.
(Psalm 119:138)[34]

Your word, O LORD, is eternal; it stands firm in the heavens.
(Psalm 119:89)[35]

The grass withers and the flowers fall, but the
word of our God stands forever.
(Isaiah 40:8)36

It is easier for heaven and earth to disappear than for the least stroke of a pen to drop out of the Law.
(Luke 16:17)[37]

Oh, that their hearts would be inclined to fear me and keep all my commands always, so that it might go well with them and their children forever!
(Deuteronomy 5:29)[38]

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So, if you have a choice between "going along" with your friends and being rebellious and sinful, try choosing God's way instead.[39] Remember what you learn in the Bible and what your parents and others teach you about God's word—and try to obey it![40]

We must obey God rather than men!
(Acts 5:29)[39]

Remember, therefore, what you have received and heard; obey it, and repent.
(**Revelation 3:3)**[40]